Secret Girl

By Molly Bruce Jacobs

INTRODUCTION

Secret Girl is the memoir of Molly Bruce Jacobs, attorney-turned-alcoholic who at age 38 first meets her sister, Anne, age 35. Anne was the family secret. Institutionalized at birth for hydrocephalus, she was supposed to die. Instead, she made such great progress her doctors wanted to discharge her. But Anne's blue-blood parents wouldn't hear of it, and ignored the repeated pleas to bring their daughter home.

In this selection "Brucie" Jacobs learns she has a secret sister for the first time. It is one of those extraordinary moments when you realize that your family history is a lie and you're forced to retrace your memories and re-evaluate their meaning. Secret Girl by Molly Bruce Jacobs.

"What would you say if I told you that you have another sister?" my father asks Laura and me.

It is 1967. I am thirteen, Laura is ten. We are staying overnight at a motel somewhere in California's Death Valley. On summer vacation, we've just driven from San Francisco and will spend about a month driving

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home cross- country, visiting the Great Salt Lake, the Grand Canyon, a dude ranch in Montana, and other places I imagine would thrill most any child.

My parents and Laura and I have almost finished dinner in the motel restaurant. Tired after being in the car all day, my mind is swirling with images of the desert. From the car, basins of sand surround us beneath the hot iron of sun. My mouth watering for a cold Coke, and in between bouts of my hogging the Barbies and leaving Laura one of those flat-staring Ken dolls, as much fun to play with as an ice pick, I watch the mirages that glisten and steam off the ribbon of road sizzling ahead. Every now and then, my eyes fasten on the desert's huge greenish gray cacti that sprout pale pink blossoms from thorny tendrils. I wonder how such a prickly plant could grow such delicate, soft things.

But what I will remember most clearly about this drive is the stifling heat. Relentless, it hangs heavy in the air. The station wagon we rented in San Francisco -- like most cars back then -- has no air-conditioning.

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"Open your window, Brad," insists my mother, fanning her face with her hands. "Girls, you too."

But Laura and I ignore her. Dice has already explained we're better off with the windows closed, and Laura and I still believe that his judgment is infallible. "You'll only be letting more heat in," Dice tells my mother again, more firmly this time.

When finally in the late afternoon we stop at the motel, Laura and I clamber out of the backseat and race to the pool. We beg Dice to take us swimming before dinner -- which he does, while our mother settles into a chair by the pool to read one of the library books she has brought on the trip.

Now Dice's question hovers above our small round table like some strange desert bird bewildered among the plastic potted plants. This is one of Dice's jokes, I think, glancing over at him to read his expression. But no, he's serious, I sense at once. I see it in the steady, concentrated look of his green eyes which are fixed on nothing in particular -- just the air in front of him -- in the scissorlike rigidity of his fingers holding the

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cigarette he has just lit, and in the grave set to his lips. What could he mean? What is he getting at?

I sneak a look over at Laura, but all her attention is on Dice. Staring at him, her small, round face has a dumbfounded, wide-eyed look of astonishment. She's waiting for him to say more, too.

As for my mother, for an eyelash of a second, a mixture of fear, sorrow, and something bitter flits across her face. Her complexion, usually reddish (from high blood pressure, I will learn later), is paling into a washed-out shade of gray, while her lips, neatly polished, are pressed together tight as two church doors. Her eyes on the white tablecloth in front of her as if she's studying some intricate pattern visible only to her, she doesn't look up.

Sensing that Dice is waiting for one of us to say something, I grope for words. Almost anything will do, I tell myself.

But before I can think of what to say, the waitress brings four white bowls full of green Jell-O topped with cold whipped cream for dessert, tea for my

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mother, and coffee for Dice. While the waitress busies herself about the table, the silence grows unbearably awkward. Either Laura or I, I don't remember who, finally blurts out something like, "What do you mean ... a sister?"

Dice waits until the waitress has left before he answers.

And then the shock comes.

"Well, you do have another sister, girls," he says, crossing one leg over the other, and sucking smoke into his lungs. As if bracing himself to go on, he leans back in his chair and clears his throat. "She's mentally retarded. She was born with a disease called water-on-the-head."

I try hard not to show it, but I am stunned. I'm not sure what has jolted me more, the news that I have another sister, or that she is mentally retarded. Both are unfathomable to my thirteen-year-old brain.

Dice is speaking again, and glancing at Laura. "She's your twin, Laura. Her name is Anne."

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Laura stiffens as if she's been stung and opens her mouth to say something. But no words come out.

Poor Laura, I think to myself, this must be weirder for her than it is for me. She's got a retarded *twin.* Is Laura going to get water-on-the-head someday, too?

Dice goes on, and, in a methodical tone of voice, gives us the bare outlines of Anne's story. She lives with other retarded children in a hospital, he tells us. "But she's happy. She's better off there with her own kind than at home." I hear him say this several times that night, and I wonder why he is repeating it.

When Dice finishes, his words don't feel real. How could we have another sister? Where is she? And what does she do all day? Can she talk? Walk? What is it like to be retarded? Why didn't he tell us about her earlier; why *now* while we're on vacation? Did Mummy know he was going to tell us? Does Nanny know about her? But tonight, instead of asking the questions tearing through my mind, I keep a grown-up, solemn look on my face, and pretend not to care.

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Laura, silent, looks bewildered, while my mother, the tension in her body unmistakable, is still staring at the table as if she's in another world. I, too, feel speechless. Still, the strain of emotion in the air is like water slowly rising all around us. Hoping to dilute it with an innocuous question, I ask where the hospital is, and what its name is.

Dice's answer gives me another shock. I hear him say in a matter-of-fact tone that Anne lives at Rosewood. It can't be, I think, horrified. Rosewood is just around the corner from Garrison Forest, the private girls' school where I'm now in seventh grade. Every once in a while, my carpool goes by Rosewood, and one or another of my friends in the car makes some crack about the "retards" who live there. I've never hesitated to join the laughter that follows. At times, I've even initiated a cruel remark or two. Now I silently swear that I won't say anything bad about retarded people ever again.

Still, images of Anne haunt me that night, keeping me awake. Every time I close my eyes, I see a grotesque

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creature with a head the size of a watermelon, her cowlike breasts the picture of obscenity. She's tucked away in the back of a closet as if she were something less than human. But the girl in the closet is screaming, shrieking in my thoughts for help; if anyone hears, they pay her no attention.

Laura, beside me in the huge double bed, is snoring lightly. Though tempted to wake her, I don't. We hardly spoke after dinner -- stunned and exhausted, we fell straight into bed. It doesn't occur to me to seek comfort from my parents in the adjoining room. Only if I were sick would I even consider disturbing them at night. I hug my knees tight to my chest and close my eyes to shut out the images of Anne, but the sound of a little girl's crying won't go away.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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